

The role of collective hypervisibility in everyday lives of refugees: the Syrian refugee hubs in metropolitan areas of Turkey

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Abstract

This paper examines refugee hubs that attract heightened scrutiny and opportunities for integration. Focusing on Turkey, we argue these hubs offer a sense of protection and expose refugees to increased control by authorities. Thus, we introduce the concept of collective hypervisibility to analyse how Syrian refugees in two Turkish hubs articulate and perceive their lived experiences through both positive and negative perspectives as a group. Refugees often view these neighbourhoods as shields from typical integration challenges faced by newcomers. However, living in such spaces also renders them targets, as all refugees are perceived as a homogeneous group, ignoring individual differences. By exploring refugee perceptions, we reveal shared dynamics across refugee hubs and offer insights relevant to similar contexts globally.

Keywords: collective hypervisibility; refugee hubs; Syrian refugees; urban space; Turkey.

1. Introduction

Syrian hubs socio-culturally and economically attract Syrians living in different parts of cities, and have become areas for living, working, and socializing among refugees. In other words, they are the nodes in cities where refugees are not only demographically concentrated but also function as focal points for refugee settlement, services, and community life due to affordable housing options, existing solidarity networks, and access to the informal labour market, ethnic goods, and services. In Turkey, there are some cities and districts that accommodate more Syrians than natives. Kilis, for instance, is a border city located in the southeast of Turkey in which the Syrian population almost surpasses the local population (Altunoluk and Koca 2022). The Reyhanlı district of Hatay, in the south of the country, is another example of a relatively large city

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(Rocha Cutiller 2021). While these examples have gained attention in terms of changing demographics, their peripheral location puts them in a position in which they are kept at arm's length. However, this has not been the case for the refugee hubs of metropolitan cities in which the presence of refugees has a distinct level of salience due to their grouping within these locations, enhancing their visibility in a collective way in urban space.

Refugees appear, show themselves, or are seen or heard by others through their existence and actions that make them more visible. Accordingly, (in)visibility can also be approached as a process, which is shaped by refugees' everyday life practices and/or power relations (Gordon 2002; Polzer and Hammond 2008). Refugees adopt (in)visibility strategies to safeguard themselves against distinct challenges (e.g. discrimination, conflict, insecurity, unsafety, illegality, informality, bureaucratic difficulties) or navigating imposed authority (Bakewell 2008; Mitra and Şahin-Mencütek 2024).

The physical space where refugees live has a significant effect on their visibility. Mitra and Şahin-Mencütek (2024) discuss the growing visibility of camp refugees compared to self-settled ones not only because these environments are known as refugee-based habitats, but also because the intra-community conflicts in these crowded and resource-limited environments worsen the reputation of refugees. On the other hand, the visibility among self-settled refugees can vary in the same city according to the characteristics of the settlement. Previous studies discuss the mobility of refugees from one neighbourhood to another to escape being highly visible or preferring refugee-inhabited areas for the facilities available in these neighbourhoods (Finiguerra 2022; Mitra and Şahin-Mencütek 2024).

The existing literature on visibility focuses on the social presence of refugees in cities that enable interaction and some level of recognition. Hypervisibility, on the other hand, discusses the conditions when this presence exceeds expected thresholds, drawing heightened and disproportionate attention to the refugees, which might trigger scrutiny, control, and stereotyping (Brighenti 2007). Yet, this literature mostly approaches visibility at the individual level, in which individual-level interactions or existence influence the overall attitudes towards refugees (Ozdemir 2024). Furthermore, what these studies lack is understanding what happens when these thresholds are crossed by refugees as a whole that can produce multidimensional outcomes for the group.

Starting from this gap, this paper examines *how the visibility of the refugee groups in neighbourhoods of metropolitan areas both influences and is influenced by refugees' everyday life at the collective level*. To address this question, we introduce the concept of *collective hypervisibility* and we define it in reference to spatially self-designated areas that offer a safe haven and home for refugees, for instance, for protection, which, at the same time, enable authorities to excessively regulate the area and put up surveillance. Collective hypervisibility builds on the negative and positive dimensions of visibility that one can experience at the individual level (Ambrosini 2013; Ozdemir 2024) while these experiences are interpreted and treated within the broader image of their refugee community (see Janmyr 2022 for Sudanese refugees in Lebanon). It brings a new layer to visibility through capturing the ambivalence of these experiences and their outcomes by bringing individual variations together within these areas as a group, demonstrating how the individual and collective dimensions interact within the hubs.

To do this, we analyse the case of Turkey, which adopted an open-door policy at the beginning of the Syrian civil war, and allowed refugees to self-settle. This led to refugee clusters in specific parts of cities, some of which turned into hubs with their own dynamics. As representatives of these areas, we analyse two Syrian refugee hubs from two metropolitan areas, Önder in Ankara and Çarşamba in Bursa. Thus, we contribute to the literature in two significant ways. First, we introduce the novel concept of *collective hypervisibility*, defined as a phenomenon that emphasises the experiences of hypervisibility as a group rather than as individuals within the refugee hubs. Second, focusing on refugee hubs provides a grounded lens that allows for a nuanced examination of how refugees' collective hypervisibility is shaped and experienced both positively and negatively in social and spatial dimensions. By doing so, the study moves beyond individual-level analyses to

capture group-level dynamics that influence refugees' lived experiences in the refugee hubs of metropolitan contexts, and broadens the scope of refugee studies to include the spatial and social dynamics that arise from and result in collective hypervisibility.

The paper is structured as follows. The following section discusses the literature on (in)visibility in migration and refugee studies and describes it as a conceptual framework. The third section details the case selection and methodology. The fourth section introduces collective hypervisibility and how it manifests itself in refugees' everyday lives in refugee hubs. The final section concludes and provides new pathways for future studies.

2. Literature on migrant and refugee visibility in everyday life

Visibility refers to the state in which refugees present themselves or become noticeable to others through their presence and actions. (In)visibility can be understood as a dynamic process shaped by refugees' daily experiences and the influence of power relations (Polzer and Hammond 2008). It reflects the responses of various stakeholders, such as refugees, the state, host communities, civil society, and international organizations when enabling visibility as a form of sociality and community (Gordon 2002) or navigating challenges and mechanisms of control. Particularly at the individual level, this sociality, or challenges that come with it, is varied due to differences mainly in nationality and ethnicity, in addition to networks involved and years spent in the host society (Chauvin and Garcés-Mascreñas 2014; Bloch and McKay 2016). Although visibility at the individual level and social networks might explain why hubs might attract refugees, they fall short in explaining how these hubs are perceived by refugees.

Thus, it is important to highlight that being invisible and visible are strategic decisions of refugees through which refugee agency is exercised (Haile 2020). Refugees prefer to remain invisible to avoid labelling, standardization, marginalization and being found and contacted, while remaining free to make choices to appear with refugee identity when they feel comfortable (Polzer 2008). This strategy helps them cope with the challenges of being a refugee, navigate insecure environments, and access informal support networks. Irregular migrants or undocumented refugees who have already been socially excluded may choose to be invisible due to their status (Polzer and Hammond 2008), which may increase their fragility as minorities that often leads to underrepresentation of their narratives and challenges they face (Borderon et al. 2021). Invisibility limits their access to services and opportunities within the formal system and the integration process (De Vries 2016). Therefore, it is a matter of 'being counted' and 'inclusion', while it may also result in social and political stigmatization, discrimination, and marginalization.

Visibility is not just related to the experiences of visual senses but also a social, relational, and spatial practice that is formed and articulated in everyday life and operates along thresholds. Particularly, hypervisibility refers to the presence of individuals or groups when they exceed accepted thresholds, in which they draw disproportionate attention (Brighenti 2007). When the visibility of the groups is below the threshold of the particular context, they might become socially and politically ignored, leading to exclusion. At the same time, too much visibility attracts public attention and institutional surveillance. Therefore, some subjects that became less visible are excluded from full participation in public life, whereas some are pushed to be hypervisible where their presence and actions are highly noticeable (Mogiani 2024).

Moreover, by imposing rules, policies, and identification, authorities use their power to make some groups visible to monitor and control them (Papadopoulos et al. 2008). Public and political performances of control, including raids, policing, and deportation, as ways of overstating the power of the state, produce migrants' visibility, even for the undocumented ones (De Genova 2002). Additionally, authorities intentionally give leeway for the clustering of refugees in some neighbourhoods of metropolitan cities in order not to generate new forms of visibility in new spaces. This allows refugees to be seen within predefined visibility thresholds to maintain control over both refugees and refugee settlements which also regulates refugee visibility in other

parts of the cities. Regarding these aspects, migrant gatherings, and ethnic businesses and services, which give rise to the reorganization of 'the partition of sensible' on who is visible (seen, heard, said) and by whom (Rancière 2004), are often accused of exceeding the 'acceptable threshold of visibility.' They generate the visibility of diverse bodies and unconventional use of urban spaces through everyday practices. This disrupts the assumed 'spatial order' regarded as the 'proper' way of using these spaces (Ambrosini 2013; Cancellieri and Ostanel 2015). This heightened visibility framed as a threat to local norms of public space use, draws disproportionate attention, often leading to excessive regulation, and contributes to the perpetuation of stereotypical representations of migrants. Thus, hypervisibility, by bringing attention to migrants, simultaneously subjects them to scrutiny, control, and oversimplified representations in urban contexts.

While hypervisibility is often associated with the challenges it poses, including increased surveillance and marginalization, it can also serve as a mechanism for protection and social mobility, and facilitate integration pathways for migrants (Wessendorf 2014). Additionally, hypervisibility can strengthen group solidarity, fostering social cohesion and mutual aid within migrant communities in which social networks lead to spatial and demographic concentration of co-ethnics in particular urban areas, making migrants more visible (Aradhya et al. 2017; Kahraman 2022). For instance, Janmyr (2022) demonstrates that group presence enables these refugees to develop representative refugee communities and refugee protests to seek protection and assistance. These indicate that through the ways developed, hypervisibility can also manifest itself as a positive outcome in the everyday lives of refugees.

The discussion on both positive and negative dimensions, and thresholds of visibility show that refugee visibility is ambivalent (De Genova 2002; Brighenti 2007) and contentious (Ataç et al. 2016) since it not only carries threats and opportunities for refugees but also is an outcome of the overlapping presence of different actors on how, where and why to be (in)visible. It is a multi-dimensional process, shaped by the legal framework and social interactions, and encountered and negotiated in urban spaces where visibility and invisibility are intertwined and consistently co-constructed context-dependently (Mokre and Six-Hohenbalken 2024).

Despite the growing body of literature, the collective hypervisibility, in which refugees in specific neighbourhoods are being treated as one large group, remains underexplored. Hence, we address existing gaps by introducing the concept of collective hypervisibility that shifts the focus from individual visibility to group-level experiences and examines how the collective presence of refugees shapes their shared, often contrasting, experiences within urban settings. This approach, being reminiscent of Çağlar and Glick Schiller's (2018) works on the agentic role of refugees in city-making, demonstrates how collective visibility contributes to reshaping urban space while increasing the public recognition of these environments. Additionally, it advances Hammond's (2004) idea of emplacement by discussing how visibility at the collective level strengthens refugees' sense of belonging, identity, and protection at refugee hubs but also complicates refugees' emplacement process by increasing scrutiny of these areas. Therefore, we expand the existing concepts further by focusing on the collective dimension of visibility that is beyond the numerical expression of refugees' demographic concentration in particular neighbourhoods but refers to a process produced and experienced socially and spatially. By emphasizing collective hypervisibility in metropolitan contexts and positioning it at the intersection of integration and regulation, the paper addresses a key gap in the literature and provides new perspectives on the socio-economic, spatial, and regulatory factors shaping refugees' group experiences in cities.

3. Case selection and methodology

Turkey has traditionally been an immigration country without a clear-cut asylum or refugee policy until the influx of Syrian refugees started in March 2011 (Sert and Daniş 2021). As a geographical limitation of the Geneva Convention in Turkey, Syrians, as non-European asylum seekers,

were not granted refugee status (Koca 2016); they are protected under temporary protection since 2014 and referred to as 'guests'. This legal framework makes them visible to the central and local authorities and allows them access to healthcare, education, and work permits after their registration. In contrast, as other irregular migrants in the country, Syrians without legal registration remain institutionally invisible which limits their access to welfare provisions. As of December 2024, the number of Syrian refugees under temporary protection reached 2,901,47 (Presidency of Migration Management [PMM] 2024), more than 98% of whom are self-settled in cities. The substantial concentration of Syrians in metropolitan neighbourhoods further reinforces their collective hypervisibility in the urban fabric.

Under the expectation of their return to Syria in the near future, Syrian refugees were welcomed by the wider public at the beginning of their migration process (Koca 2016) which facilitated their resettlement process. However, because of their extended stay in the country, their increasing visibility led to intolerance from local citizens, anti-Syrian sentiments, hate speech, and an increase in violent incidents (Sert and Daniş 2021). Turkey's prolonged economic challenges, along with competing interests between locals and Syrians, have stimulated tension between the local and refugee populations. The visibility of Syrians in public spaces is often perceived as a threat to the existing cities' social order (Narli and Özaşçılar 2020), a burden to the socio-economic system leading to economic competition, and asymmetrical distribution of aid in favour of refugees.

As salient spatial representations of refugees' everyday lives, refugee hubs have emerged as a focal point of attention in the eyes of the public and refugees themselves. Their potentials and challenges make them suitable locations for the investigation of refugees' hypervisibility. Within this framework, this study conducted a neighbourhood-level analysis in two different settlements of two different non-border metropolitan cities of Turkey, which are brought into the spotlight as Syrian refugee hubs. Önder (Ankara) and Çarşamba (Bursa) neighbourhoods, both known as 'Little Aleppo' after the arrival of Syrians, were chosen as study areas of this investigation. Beyond their appropriateness for addressing the research question, the selection of these neighbourhoods to provide a complementary picture of how visibility is produced and experienced in urban contexts was shaped by our sustained engagement with them since 2016 and 2017. This long-term involvement has given deep familiarity with their everyday life, socio-economic dynamics, and the processes that Syrian refugees experience there from their initial resettlement to integration along with the challenges and opportunities they encounter. Our established connections with refugee-oriented associations and local organisations, neighbourhood mukhtars, and refugee networks operating in the site help us understand the contextual dynamics of the study area. Moreover, our previous examinations in these areas facilitated trust-building, access to participants, and deeper insights into formal and informal mechanisms shaping their material, economic, and social environment.

While both neighbourhoods have similarities regarding refugee arrivals as well as housing and working areas for refugees, each displays unique features in becoming Syrian hubs. Ankara and Bursa are, respectively, the second and fourth-largest provinces in the country and host the 10th and 7th largest refugee populations, with 84,541 and 167,859 Syrian refugees (PMM 2024). Ankara, the capital and administrative centre of Turkey, has become a hotspot for Syrian refugee resettlement due to its institutional capacity and less-developed settlements linked to industrial districts. Bursa is an industrial city, renowned for its rich migration history, and it attracts Syrian refugees with its robust industrial infrastructure and related employment opportunities. The city's historical, cultural, and commercial ties with Aleppo, particularly in the textile industry, further contribute to its attractiveness (Kaya 2023).

Önder is located in the north-eastern part of the Ankara metropolitan area, 10 km from the city centre. The demographic change of the neighbourhood started with the arrival of rural migrants from Central Anatolia in the late 1950s who illegally constructed their squatter houses on agricultural land. Since the 1980s, the residents whose socio-economic status improved moved out of the neighbourhood. The transformation of nearby neighbourhoods in the 2000s

pushed their tenants to Önder which gradually has become the site for the urban poor. Moreover, refugees from Iraq, Afghanistan, Somalia, and later Syria started to move to the neighbourhood. The resettlement of Syrian refugees began in 2012 and gained momentum with the designation of Önder as an urban renewal area in 2015, leading to the relocation of local residents. The industrial district intertwined with Önder offers employment opportunities in furniture manufacturing (Kahraman 2022). Affordable rentals have created opportunities for small Syrian enterprises and trade activities, not only serving Önder's Syrian residents but also Syrians from different parts of the city. Finally, some NGOs started to operate in the neighbourhood to support the integration of Syrian refugees. Consequently, Önder has become a refugee hub by serving the economic and social needs of Syrian refugees (Kahraman 2022).

Similarly, Çarşamba, which is located in the Bursa metropolitan area and is two kilometres from the city centre, consists of eight neighbourhoods acting as one large neighbourhood. Çarşamba has been through a demographic change starting in the 1980s when upper-middle-class apartment owners moved to the western parts of the city. In the 1990s, sex workers arrived to the neighbourhood from different parts of the province. Their departure was followed by the arrival of Roma people during the 2000s who stayed in Çarşamba as tenants until the late 2000s (Irgil 2022). As housing complexes were established in other parts of Bursa, some tenants moved out to those areas, leaving Çarşamba with a supply of empty apartments and shops. Finally, Çarşamba hosted the arrival of many Syrians with its proximity to the city centre and the availability of housing options. Similar to Önder, the subsequent establishment of Syrian businesses further helped Çarşamba appeal to the interests of many resident and non-resident Syrians for shopping and socialising purposes which transformed the neighbourhood into a refugee hub.

The data collection process started with in situ observations and informal conversations with residents where we documented everyday practices in the study area. Such observations and conversations providing contextual insights complemented and enriched the data collected through semi-structured in-depth interviews with Syrian refugees. The interviews were conducted in 2019 in Arabic, the native language of the respondents, with the assistance of a translator from the neighbourhood in Önder and a research assistant from Syria in Çarşamba. As two Turkish female researchers, we were aware of our positionality and the asymmetries that conducting such research might generate. Therefore, we acknowledged our role as an outsider combined with gendered and national dynamics and continuously reflected on the interactions to mitigate power imbalances (Carling et al. 2014). While we attended all the interviews to observe and to take notes, the Syrian translator and research assistant took active roles to introduce us as researchers to the potential participants, to ease communication, and to facilitate initial trust-building between us and respondents. In addition, they contributed to the recruitment of respondents by encouraging their willingness to participate and for their openness while answering questions, and provided cultural interpretation whenever needed.

The NGO representatives, neighbourhood mukhtars, pioneering refugees that we met in our previous investigations, and refugees that we met during our site visits for this study in both Önder and Çarşamba guided us while reaching potential respondents of the study. Among those respondent pools, we employed convenience sampling to recruit easily accessible respondents in terms of location and availability (Ritchie et al. 2013). In other words, the sample includes Syrian refugees living in the area who were willing and available to participate in our study within the time framework of our fieldwork. Although this approach excluded more isolated and less willing Syrians from the data collection process that limited more diverse perspectives, it allowed us to conduct the study with respondents who felt comfortable in sharing their experiences in detail. The sample in Önder was composed of 22 female and 19 male respondents aged between 21 and 69 with a total of 41 respondents. In Çarşamba, the sample consists of 40 respondents, composed of 33 males and 7 females aged between 18 and 57. In both cases, the majority of interviewees are primary and secondary school graduates. Their duration of stay in Turkey, Ankara and Bursa, and the neighbourhoods varied from one to eight years. The entire sample in Önder and the majority of the sample in Çarşamba both lived and worked in the neighbourhoods.

In all the interviews, we informed our respondents about the study and the freedom to withdraw whenever they wanted. The interviewing process based on the verbal consent of each respondent lasts from 1–2 hours on average. All interviews were performed face-to-face on the streets, in neighbourhood parks and Syrian-owned shops, depending on the preference of participants. In Önder, all interviews were recorded, then transcribed and translated into Turkish and finally, manually coded in English. In Çarşamba, all interviews were handwritten following the wishes of the respondents, which increased comfort, trust and rapport, and to guarantee the utmost accuracy, the interviews were shown to respondents and corrected accordingly, which were followed by typing the interviews into a laptop. Subsequently, the interviews were coded in Atlas.ti. To offer anonymity, in both cases, we used codes for respondents. In Önder, they are coded with O, for instance O2, and in Çarşamba, as C, for example C2. This helps us show the different sources of the quotes, while offering anonymity.

4. Collective hypervisibility in refugee hubs

Building on the body of literature highlighting the role of visibility in establishing collective characteristics, we discuss different layers of collective hypervisibility reflecting both its positive and negative impacts on refugees' everyday lives in refugee hubs.

4.1 Collective hypervisibility as solidarity

Refugee neighbourhoods provide *safe and secure grounds for newcomers in terms of providing a gathering and solidarity space*. Although these hubs lead to socio-spatial segregation and hinder interaction with the rest of the city and its society, they are strong candidates for being safe sanctuaries to establish a new life for newcomers. They display similarities with the country of origin, where refugees can explore familiarity and shared identity. Seeing co-ethnics on the streets, living in the same neighbourhood, interacting in their mother tongue, and benefiting from the mutual support of their networks all contribute to refugees' perception of these neighbourhoods as protective and trustworthy environments. These networks have a significant role in facilitating refugees' everyday lives by informing, guiding, and supporting them in accessing the labour and housing markets, services, and opportunities of representation (Bertrand et al. 2000; Trevena et al. 2013).

In both Önder and Çarşamba, the similar migration and resettlement experiences, and paths of the members of these networks help newcomers navigate the unfamiliar social, economic, and bureaucratic systems. These networks, as sources of mutual aid and resource sharing, provide practical solutions to make survival manageable, reduce the cost of living, and enhance personal and collective resilience (Aradhya et al. 2017). O10 explained the support of his social networks in coping with everyday challenges as:

When I wake up, I sometimes have a strange feeling of loneliness. But, after I go out and see my countrymen, although I do not know all of them, it provides relief to my heart. Unfortunately, I have little time to spend with them as I return from work around 8 pm. However, whenever I am in a tight spot, trying to solve a daily problem or seeking advice, I know they understand my situation and support me if they are able to.

Family members, close relatives, and acquaintances are accepted as the most trustworthy members of solidarity networks, which give refugees the sense that they are 'not in a foreign country' or 'as they were in Syria' (C13, C36, O31, O35). C14 explained being surrounded by his trusted companions, which also shapes his choice of living in Çarşamba, as 'All my people, I know, are here, and it's hard to go to another area. I see and feel them and they feel me. I have my contacts around me which makes me feel as if I were in Syria rather than in a foreign country'. Similarly, the ones in Önder describe their neighbourhood as places of 'being a community' (O27) and 'living easier than elsewhere in the city' (O39). C21 added the role of country fellows from different parts of Syria in the construction of refugee hubs as gathering and solidarity

spaces, 'So there was a cooperation even between the Syrians who came from different cities, like Aleppo and Damascus, who got together and all of them came to live in Çarşamba'.

The public spaces, including the streets, parks, and commercial streets of these hubs, have become a performative space of visibility where Syrian residents of Önder and Çarşamba, and Syrians living in different parts of Ankara and Bursa gather and interact with their co-ethnics. O27 portrayed the meaning of being in Önder to him as 'I come here to see my Syrian community; then, I hang out with friends and meet my needs. The more people (Syrians) on the streets and the more we interact, the more I feel settled'. Similarly, O21 reported the effects of solidarity relations among Syrians on strengthening their community bonds, sense of safety, and integration:

I miss my land, my old days in Syria. Thank God that we have our own community here. When I go to the mosque, I feel them and I feel secure. Praying, chatting and shopping with friends and seeing the congregation empowers this feeling.

This quote also exemplifies that Syrian refugees' shared identity, daily activities, and religious practices are exercised together in the same residential area which echoes [Polzer \(2008\)](#)'s discussion on the role of visibility in identity, membership, and collectiveness generation in addition to the establishment of sociality and community ([Gordon 2002](#)). This collectiveness eases the emotional burdens of displacement, reduces the feeling of isolation, and helps them adapt to their new lives ([Kahraman 2023](#)).

All these findings show that Önder and Çarşamba, becoming commercial, spatial, and socio-cultural attractions for Syrian refugees citywide, increase refugees' collective hypervisibility in which the acceptable threshold has been exceeded collectively ([Ambrosini 2013](#); [Cancellieri and Ostanel 2015](#)). This hypervisibility underscores the question of whose neighbourhoods they are ([Rancière 2004](#)). On the other hand, the solidarity networks that emerged in these hubs provide a sense of community, empowerment, security, and attachment ([Aradhya et al. 2017](#)) to Syrian refugees which infuse a collective symbolic and emotional meaning to these neighbourhoods.

4.2 Collective hypervisibility as integration

An increase in the refugee population in specific neighbourhoods offers housing, livelihood and socialisation opportunities. Additionally, through their culturally resonant environments and formal and informal networks, these neighbourhoods act as protective buffers against integration challenges for newly arrived individuals. Moreover, the presence of community organizations and informal support systems discussed above helps newcomers build connections and gradually integrate into the broader society while maintaining their cultural identity ([Wessendorf 2014](#)). Thus, migrants within these hubs benefit from access to resources and a shared sense of belonging that eases their adaptation into a new place ([Aradhya et al. 2017](#); [Kahraman 2023](#)). All these characteristics of refugee hubs enable refugees to have facilitated *resettlement and integration processes* that can be challenging in the absence of long-term resettlement and integration policies in countries like Turkey.

Over time, both Önder and Çarşamba have evolved from refugee-populated neighbourhoods into refugee hubs, shaped by the needs, habits, lifestyle and social networks of the Syrian community ([Mazumdar et al. 2000](#)). The growing number of Syrians, along with group-based economic activities in these areas, including the ethnic businesses, participation in the informal market, support from formal and informal structures, and strong community solidarity, has transformed these areas into focal points that also attract Syrians living in other parts of Ankara and Bursa. These dynamics and everyday practices performed in these hubs contribute to Syrian refugees' collective hypervisibility.

Additionally, the crowded marketplaces of both neighbourhoods demonstrate rich cultural symbols of the Syrian community with some contemporary influence, such as clothing style, the scent of Syrian food, and conversations in Arabic. They, collectively, nurture the cultural, economic, spatial, and physical visibility of Syrian refugees in Önder and Çarşamba, the vibrant

grounds for the exchange of a shared culture and identity (Wessendorf 2014). O39's quote illustrates the comfort of Syrian refugees in refugee hubs, promoting a feeling of connection, 'Life is easier here than living in another neighbourhood of the city. Because I have everything here to sustain my life and meet my needs. I feel comfortable here. We [Syrians] are lucky to have Önder'. Furthermore, self-sufficient Syrian communities in both Önder and Çarşamba reduce the need to interact with the local community (Alhusban et al. 2019) and learn their language (Zorlu and Hartog 2018). O6 highlighted the dominance of her daily interaction with the Syrian community in Arabic which led her to discontinue learning Turkish, 'At first, I went to the Turkish courses of the Municipality. But, then, I did not continue them as I live here. The majority of Önder's population is Syrian and our language is spoken here'.

In contrast to the literature supporting the influence of learning the language of the host country in facilitating the communication between host and refugee communities and refugees' integration into the host society (Zorlu and Hartog 2018), many respondents expressed communicating in their mother tongue as a facilitator of both everyday life and sense of safety as if they were in Syria. C18 voiced this perception as 'I feel as if I were in my country. It feels good to find people who can speak Arabic. They understand you, you feel much safer and you do not struggle a lot'. These illustrate that communicating in the mother tongue helps refugees perceive refugee hubs as safe places, where there is limited interaction between local and refugee societies, in which refugees cope collectively.

4.3 Collective hypervisibility as threat

As discussed above, spatially segregated ethnic settlements limit intergroup contact, trigger threat perceptions, and consequently worsen immigration attitudes (Laurence and Goebel 2025). They generate a generalised framework for refugees and a limited understanding of the internal diversity and complexity within refugee communities. The most common outcome for collective hypervisibility is stereotyping. This leads to refugees being represented through a narrow perspective, disconnected from their individuality, and subjected to judgments and assumptions (Zetter 1991).

Thus, as much as its advantages, the hypervisibility in refugee hubs also manifests itself as a threat when it comes to *stereotyping as labelling of and racism against* refugees in these areas. Stereotyping simplifies their identity by categorizing them based on shared visible or perceived traits, behaviours, and needs (Zetter 1991), resulting in their collective perception as a singular, homogeneous group by both locals and authorities. As Ozdemir (2024) points out, these can result in both micro- and macro-aggressions that manifest themselves in the everyday life of refugees. For example, comments about someone's language proficiency leading to tension between two parties may intensify, fuel prejudices, and eventually escalate into discriminatory behaviours.

Similarly, Syrian refugees' practices in experiencing their own culture and language in both Önder and Çarşamba, explained above as their tactics of survival and integration, also act as the reasons for being singled-out as 'Syrians' by the locals. C14 voiced the complaints of many respondents:

Sometimes the Turkish neighbours are getting upset from the presence of the Syrians, and there are problems happening sometimes. Even if you have nothing to do with the problem, the Turks accuse you because you are Syrian. You feel yourself ostracised in the area.

This quotation not only highlights the stereotyping of Syrian refugees (Brighenti 2007) but also opens the discussion for the negative consequences of Syrians' hypervisibility in refugee hubs. First, the collective hypervisibility and overrepresentation of refugees have generated public discontent, pushed the limits of the tolerance of locals towards Syrians, and sometimes resulted in *tensions between local and Syrian residents* in Önder and Çarşamba. This tension culminates in violent incidents such as arson of Syrian-owned stores, wounded Syrian and local individuals, and even sometimes loss of life (Bursada Bugun 2018; BBC News 2021). Incidents

stopped by the police harmed peaceful relations between the two societies, resulting in a change in safety perceptions of both sides. They intensified security-related concerns of local residents in relation to the existence of Syrian refugees and Syrian refugees' feelings of apprehension (Açıklan et al. 2021; Kahraman 2023). In response to these incidents and the growing dominance of Syrian refugees, some local residents have left Önder. Many others displayed the Turkish flag on the walls and windows of their homes and shops to assert their identity, distinguish themselves from Syrian refugees (Irgil 2022; Kahraman 2023), and reinforce their presence and diminishing visibility in the neighbourhood.

Second, these incidents and their consequences have generated significant challenges in Syrian refugees' everyday life in refugee hubs where they are collectively hypervisible. O1 demonstrated labelling as the direct consequences of the collective hypervisibility, 'There are many Syrians here. Everyone knows that you are Syrian. There is no way to escape from this title here'. Similarly, C27 explained stereotyping as the disadvantages of living in Çarşamba, 'There is a lot of pressure on the Syrians here. [...] And they are judging all the Syrians from the behaviour of some bad Syrians. If one Syrian made a mistake, they judge and punish them all'. O2 added 'I'm not me when I'm walking on the street. I'm one of the Syrians in the eyes of locals'. These quotations describe 'the cost of living' (O11) in these hubs regardless of Syrian refugees' other interactions, good intentions, and proper attitudes in the public space.

Finally, the cost of Syrian refugees' collective hypervisibility also reflected on Syrian refugees' perception of how they are viewed by the local people and their definitions of the distinction between Turks and Syrians. Many respondents in both neighbourhoods emphasised the feeling that 'all eyes are on us [Syrians]' (C34), reflecting their sense of being perceived by the locals as 'strange' (C25), 'big threat' (O16), and 'problem' (O29). O6 reflected on his perception of negative sentiments, 'Although I have no problems with my Turkish neighbours, I feel that they are not fond of us'. O12 reported his experience with a local vendor, highlighting perceptions of differences as 'He asked me whether I knew the difference between a Turkish and a Syrian, and he answered that a Turkish is a Turkish that Syrians can never be'. More severely, C23 interpreted racism as a consequence of the hypervisibility of Syrian refugees, 'Because this is a Syrian-gathering area, there is a lot of racism in dealing with some Turkish citizens'. Additional anecdotes, such as 'Turks not liking Syrians' (O39) and 'Turks disturbing Syrians' (C15), underline the othering perspectives and intercommunal tensions that sometimes culminate in physical confrontations in both neighbourhoods. Consequently, as C18 voiced, many respondents complained about the decreasing quality of life in refugee hubs because of the hypervisibility of Syrian refugees:

There are lots of problems that are affecting our social life, there is always anxiety. [...] I am discontent with living in an area full of Syrians, because whatever any single Syrian does, it will include all the other Syrians as one in the area.

His words not only highlight the perception of being viewed as Syrians as a group within the broad refugee image (Janmyr 2022) creating problems, but also serve as a critique of Syrian counter fellows disrupting the peace in refugee neighbourhoods due to collective hypervisibility.

4.4 Collective hypervisibility under surveillance

The collective hypervisibility of refugees may expose them to other risks, including being targeted by the authorities, facing potential arrest, detention, deportation, or abuse, and resisting being categorized as illegal migrants while asserting their rights and presence. Foucault (1995) associates visibility with subjugation, discipline, and social control. When subjects have access to the public domain and take collective action, because of their increasing visibility, they are exposed to the power of the authorities (Marquez 2012), leading to the disempowerment of the visible group.

Thus, collective hypervisibility makes refugee hubs *targets of the local authorities* (Marquez 2012) including the provincial directorate of security and the municipal police in the study area.

Both local authorities, having direct regulatory power to protect public order in urban areas, impose governing practices through the implementation of regulations in refugee hubs that contribute to refugees' visibility. The police force belonging to the provincial directorate of security is responsible for maintaining law in relation to the social order and public safety in those areas through their patrols and investigations. It enforces 'regular' (O4, C16) local regulations and city ordinances to maintain public order, peace, and health through its controls. O5 reported:

Police are everywhere. You see them at the entrances of the neighbourhood with their cars. Plainclothes police are roaming around as well. They are taking precautions for the possible tension between Syrian and Turkish people, which I can understand. However, I do not take this as just ordinary precautions.

The increasing police checks and patrols after incidents in Önder and Çarşamba neighbourhoods are considered threatening, controlling (Narli and Özaşçılar 2020), intrusive (Griffiths 2018), and intimidating by Syrian refugees in addition to 'being too much' (C7). The sample associates the presence of police in their neighbourhood space with security risks, criminal activities, and a heightened sense of insecurity and fear. Therefore, these checks increased their discomfort and stress about being visible in public spaces.

As the second local authority, the municipal police maintain public order and safety, enforce local regulations and measurements on health standards, waste and traffic management, and oversee construction and the market within municipal boundaries (Official Gazette 2007). Their checks especially manifested themselves as controls of the use of Arabic on commercial signs in both neighbourhoods, as they were experienced in many other localities in Turkey, followed by the increase in Syrian population in these areas (Irgil 2022). O12, O20, C6, C7, all reported that shop signs in Arabic were replaced with signs in Turkish after the enforcement of these rules in both neighbourhoods. It can be said that the growing visibility of Syrian shops in Arabic, illustrating the expanding presence of Syrian refugees and their businesses, prompted municipal authorities both to regulate Syrians' commercial activities and assert their authority and institutional power of surveillance (McWilliams and Bonet 2015). The overstating of authority for regularizing the spatial order (Ambrosini 2013) exceeded the accepted threshold (Brighenti 2007) drew more public attention to refugee neighbourhoods which adds more to the collective hypervisibility of Syrian refugees (De Genova 2002).

O7 interpreted the surveillance efforts as, 'Since our population has been increasing here, we are receiving much more attention from authorities. Their control on our shops has been increasing'. Apart from their target to minimize the public visibility of shops, O22 added, on these random municipal police controls and shop visits, 'The people are not happy with our presence. They do not want to see Syrian people or signs in Arabic. That's why the signs were changed'. His words reflect the perception of many respondents being undesirable as Syrian refugees and Syrian-owned businesses. This shows the meaning of shop signs as contested markers highlighting the collective hypervisibility of Syrian refugees in study areas. Furthermore, collective hypervisibility is accepted as an expression of cultural difference and identity, generating discontent among locals and compelling local authorities to take restrictive interventions to regulate this discontent.

5. Conclusion

This study introduced the concept of *collective hypervisibility* and examined the dynamics and impacts of visibility as a group on the everyday lives of refugees who are residing, working and utilising refugee hubs of metropolitan areas. Collective hypervisibility advances our understanding of visibility as a group. The collective level dynamics, including spatial, social, and regulatory dimensions, provide new insights into how urban space itself and experiences emerge on it shape refugees' experiences both in negative and positive ways. This concept, contributing to the existing literature, differentiates itself from the existing literature by demonstrating the

outcomes of passing a threshold as a group within a given space. With a special focus on Syrian refugees in Önder and Çarşamba neighbourhoods of Ankara and Bursa in Turkey, the findings highlighted both the positive and negative dimensions and multiple layers of collective hypervisibility.

Demonstrating its positive impacts, first, findings on collective hypervisibility as solidarity showed that refugee hubs provide safe and secure grounds for refugees' solidarity through providing practical clues and solutions for everyday life by making survival easier. Thus, refugee hubs as spatial representatives of these networks enhance the sense of togetherness, community, belonging and safety where refugees gather, interact and cooperate, stimulating the collective hypervisibility of the refugee community as a group that attracts many other refugees. Second, collective hypervisibility in refugee hubs mediates various factors of integration. In addition to the solidarity networks, the socio-cultural and economic environment of refugee neighbourhoods enables refugees to meet their everyday needs and cultural preferences, and sustain their routines and lifestyle, particularly language. The commercial relations facilitated by Syrian entrepreneurs, goods and services, and marketplaces demonstrating rich cultural symbols including cuisine, dressing and language contribute to refugee hypervisibility on one hand and promote their integration on the other.

In contrast to positive impacts, collective hypervisibility results in negative perceptions, prejudices, actions, and control over refugee hubs. As a part of these complexities, the findings discussed refugee hubs as places of collective hypervisibility heightened potential threats for refugees. The understanding of evaluating refugees as a single group fuels prejudices, reinforces exclusion and discrimination, legitimizes unequal treatment, and erodes opportunities for social cohesion. These generalized images exacerbated during social and economic uncertainties trigger the tendency for othering, in which language, together with other cultural identifiers of the refugee community, become visible markers of difference. Hence, these everyday dynamics create cyclical processes where intergroup conflicts occur, hindering intercultural dialogue and worsening the intragroup divisions within the refugee community. Furthermore, the growing collective hypervisibility of refugees, primarily when security incidents occur, draws the attention of authorities to handle the crisis occurring in the public space and regulate public discontent. Corresponding adapted regulatory frameworks, including increasing police checks and patrols, and enforcing new local measures, not only highlight the power of the authority but also increase the perception that refugee neighbourhoods are under a security risk or constitute a threat to social order. Therefore, each intervention to regulate everyday life in refugee hubs providing more surveillance contributes to the refugees' collective hypervisibility, which in turn may discourage their everyday interactions and reinforce social boundaries on one hand, and may draw public attention to those areas triggering collective hypervisibility on another.

Hence, this study, moving beyond individual analysis to uncover dynamics influencing the everyday life of refugees, contributes to the growing body of (in)visibility literature in refugee studies in two significant ways. First, it extended the definition of hypervisibility by adding a collective dimension in which refugees' high visibility and overrepresentation function as both a mechanism of their empowerment and a condition that invites negative perceptions of refugees and radicalized surveillance. The collective hypervisibility enabling solidarity, protection, and opportunities for integration and belonging make refugees legible to authorities and the public. Therefore, collective hypervisibility emerges as both a resource and a threat for refugees in which the empowerment mechanism is simultaneously co-produced with monitoring, control, stereotyping and the risk of stigmatizing in refugee hubs. This collective dimension intensifying the contradictory, ambivalent and dynamic nature of hypervisibility enriches the discussions both on refugee integration and the power relations in refugee settlements.

Second, the analysis in two different metropolitan cities from Turkey complementing each other revealed shared patterns and local dynamics for hypervisibility in refugee hubs. This analysis contributes to the understanding of a nuanced perspective on how refugees' collective visibility is socio-spatially produced and reflected on both everyday life and the urban space that

can be expanded to other similar contexts. It concretises refugee hubs as sites where community life, livelihood activities, spatial aggregation, and physical presence overlap and produce collective hypervisibility. This contribution, deepening the discussions on the interaction between space, everyday life, and presence, also highlights refugees' collective practices performed on refugee hubs as evidence of urban presence.

Finally, this study opens up a wide array of interdisciplinary research directions. A group of studies may examine the impacts of refugees' collective hypervisibility on their labour and housing market inclusion. Another group of studies may focus on perceptions of authorities and local people on refugees' collective hypervisibility. These studies may investigate how authorities and locals interpret refugees' collective hypervisibility and how their understanding shapes their responses, including strategies and attitudes towards refugees accordingly. Finally, some others might interrogate the strategies of different groups within the refugee community, including undocumented, youth, and workers in different contexts.

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Conflict of interest

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